

Return to EDEN

When India play South Africa next, it is not only Dhoni's men who will face a test. Eden Gardens itself is struggling to regain its status.

By Elora Sen

No wonder Eden stands for paradise. Not in the Old Testament but in the books of Indian cricket. Whenever the Indian team arrives in Kolkata, bruised or battered, the giant soup plate has always given them something for the soul. In its last 10 Tests, India have won five, and lost only two. The last defeat was more than 10 years ago to Pakistan, followed, of course, by the miracle of 2001.

Once again this week, India return to Eden Gardens, their number one Test ranking and collective egos pounded by the visiting South Africans. When M.S. Dhoni's men look around the ground, they will know that repair is due. Of all kinds. Not just their batting line-up and bowling attack, but at the very stadium which gives India its edge.

Eden Gardens itself has, of course, been going longer than India's number one ranking. The first Test match was held here in 1934, and India versus South Africa, the first in two years, is its 36th. Eden has not been completely starved of action since the last drawn Test versus Pakistan in 2007. It played its part in the Indian Premier League's hectic first season in 2008 and staged a lone Christmas eve ODI against Sri Lanka where India won but the lights failed.

Still, it is Test matches that remain the big daddies of international cricket, giving grounds its atmosphere and status. So apart from Dhoni's men, Eden Gardens itself is getting ready for an examination of whether it remains one of the premier venues of in-

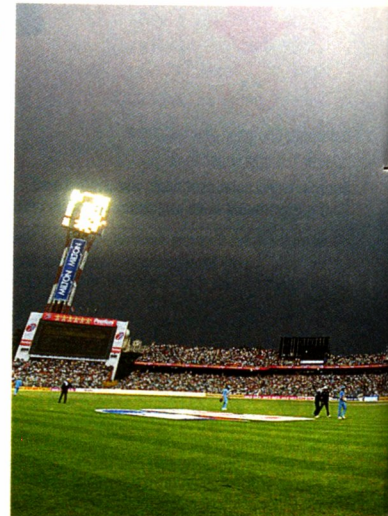
ternational cricket. What makes this examination a little tougher is the fact that the ground has been turned inside out in an ongoing renovation which has robbed it of as many as 60,000 spectators. Even Cricket Association of Bengal (CAB) insiders know that hosting a Test match in a stadium which is partially under construction is far from easy. And Eden Gardens without its one lakh spectators seems like an ocean without its rolling surf.

The India versus South Africa Test has another sub-plot. For the Jagmohan Dalmiya-led CAB administration, it is also a chance to prove that they are back in business. The last Test at Eden was held way back in 2007 with the then commissioner of police Prasun Mukherjee heading the CAB.

Dalmiya, 70, is an old hand, be it organising matches or dealing with BCCI's politics. The man who had total control over Indian cricket until Sharad Pawar got into the act, and Lalit Modi rose to prominence, has been lying low for a while. But having



EDEN GARDENS UNDER RENOVATION (ABOVE); THE NEW-LOOK GROUND MAY NOT HOST A LAKH LIKE IT USED TO



AP PHOTO

cleared many legal hurdles and winning cases that were filed against him by the BCCI's current regime, he seems ready for more action—and this Test could be a flexing of some old muscle.

Asked just why the CAB is eager to host a Test in a semi-complete stadium which will hold just 45,000 people, Dalmiya explains, "This was our turn and we didn't want to lose that.